

MeeGo tablet?

An unidentified tablet-shaped Nokia device running its MeeGo operating system was recently leaked

The year of the tablet?

A lot has been spoken about tablets and expectations of this product segment is rising rapidly

eBook test

especially if you get carried away with your newly found wonder. You'd have to hold yourself from clicking too fast. Quoting Ralph Waldo Emerson, the famous American Poet and Author, *"For everything you have missed, you have gained something else, and for everything you gain, you lose something else."* Touch capabilities are definitely possible, as Leaf has proved, but at the cost of rich user experience.

We'd rather have our devices evolving to suit our needs – it could've even been a tablet (or getting specific even the iPad) for that matter. But the one distinguishing factor when you pick up an ebook reader, and eink specifically, is its readability in sunlight.

All standard dedicated ebook readers are available only in monochrome due to limitations in currently available technologies. The devices that claim to be colour ebook readers, don't give you a strain-free experience due to back-lit displays. The most significant flaw any ebook reader could have is a resemblance to a standard monochrome LCD display – precisely what we felt from the Leaf Touch. From the host of readers we received, the basic Touch model made us feel we're reading from a device, which we believe defeats the purpose of having a reader. The readability experience reminds you of the rather nostalgic monochrome LCD displays.

The specifications claim support for audio, but when we tried to play some standard MP3 samples, it simply wouldn't budge. Owing to its resistive screen, it claims to support finger-touch, but you'd rather prefer the stylus with some decent taps instead.

Other than that, Leaf has a really portable product with a minimalist interface and sturdy build (giving it a rubberised body). There are just four buttons in addition to the essential power switch on the



Leaf Touch: electronic

front itself. A big turn off was the time you need to wait to transfer a book collection. Our sample of 177 books totalling to 100 MB took a ridiculous 15 minutes to transfer. Compare that to an average of 2.5 minutes across other ebook readers and it's no match.

Leaf Touch Pro

This seemed to be the fastest among the ebook readers

we received from Leaf. Also, compared to the Infibeam Pi, it felt much better. There are several functions visible in the menu, but quite a few work badly. For example, there is an option for handwriting to jot notes. It couldn't recognise a single letter or number! Even the QWERTY option had significant lag that made it an inconvenient option. Rather the scribbling function seems more easy and convenient to use. When taking notes however, the erase tool erases strokes at once, instead of pixels and so if you would write a word in a single stroke, then a swipe with the eraser would delete the whole word. The dictionary doesn't serve a purpose, and hints at something amiss.

The power switch at the bottom of the body is rather inconvenient again. Especially while lying down or relaxing, you can inadvertently trigger it to go into standby mode.

We liked the build quality of the reader, and it has a sturdy feel to it. This is enhanced by the aluminium base. It weighs 250 grams and has a dial with four buttons to navigate through your books. Navigating pages gets strenuous on the thumb over prolonged use. Since the buttons

are on the base, changing positions doesn't make a significant difference.

As is evident, it is easy to get distracted by functions other than its core function – reading books. Once again, all it has is 512 MB of memory. The best feature set is the sheer number of formats supported – an impressive list.



Touch Pro: For the pro

HOW WE TESTED

Build and ergonomics

To test ergonomics and weight, we compared it to a standard paperback and hardcover book. The factors on which we rated the ebook reader was weight, dimensions, grip, placement of buttons, etc. Also, the comfort factor was considered during prolonged use – a few hours a day each, for almost a month. This was to ensure that although some devices seem well designed to begin with, it's only after you actually read on them for a few days that you realise how good or bad it is to hold.

Readability

To test readability, we viewed each ebook reader at various angles with changing scenarios of light source in 4 different directions. The tilt at which readability was hampered was factored in arriving at our decision regarding screen capability. Additionally, we transferred a PDF consisting of text of various font sizes, both in monochrome and colour, with a test image indicating multiple levels of gray in steps as well as a uniform gradient. The displayed results were compared to a standard print on an A4-sized paper printed using an HP inkjet colour printer.



Paper vs. E-Ink: Fight!

File transfer and speed

The whole advantage of ebook readers is that you can carry hundreds of books around with you. Thus, the time taken to add those books to the device is important. We measured the fastest possible data transfer speeds between a test PC and the device. Our sample comprises 177 assorted books and novels from various authors and poets that totalled to exactly 100 MB of data. We also tested the speed of the device itself when handling ebooks. After all, the time taken to open a book, flip a page and search for something is important to the feel of the device.

Other tests

We gave added points to a device's ability to look up the meaning of words, take notes, etc. In any area where there was subjectivity involved – such as the UI design, ease of use, search implementation, etc. We've also tried to minimise any bias by getting four members of Team Digit to independently rate any subjective features on a scale of 10, and then averaged out the score.